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Original Article

Service Quality and Customer Satisfaction: A Meta-Analysis of Service Quality Dimensions

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Globally, there is high competition in the market, leading organisations to set strategies that focus on customer satisfaction. Therefore, customers have remained the centre of focus in organisations, and there is a great need to satisfy them. One of the strategies is service quality, which is crucial for customer satisfaction. The study aims to examine the effect of service quality on customer satisfaction in the service industry. A desk review of the literature was used in the study. The SERVQUAL model was adopted, which is based on five dimensions: reliability, assurance, tangibles, empathy and responsiveness. Assimilation theory explained the relationship between expectations and perceived product performance. There exists evidence that shows that there is a relationship between service quality and customer satisfaction. However, customer satisfaction has a mediating effect between service quality and customer loyalty. The study concluded that reliability, assurance, tangibles, empathy and responsiveness as dimensions of service quality had a significant relationship with customer satisfaction. Other studies used different dimensions such as credibility, competency, security, communication, courtesy, access and assurance. Competency, tangibility, assurance and credibility dimensions were found to have a high impact on customer satisfaction. The study recommends improving the reliability of the services through creating consistent quality and timelines to ensure quality delivery. The study further recommends that organisations should ensure a high-quality experience during provision to gain functional and competitive advantage.

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INTRODUCTION

Quality service is a very important aspect that creates a pool of satisfied customers. Organisations can be able to thrive amid stiff competition by offering superior services to attain a competitive edge in the world market. Success in global competition is determined by how well service-offering organisations can adopt the culture of providing quality service to their customers (Paposa, 2019).

Customer satisfaction is the attitude that customers exhibit towards the service provider. It can also be viewed as an emotional response towards the expectation and the actual results achieved (Gera, Mittal, Batra & Prasad, 2017). Customer satisfaction is the consumer's response to the evaluation of the perceived discrepancy between prior expectations and the actual performance of the product or service as perceived after its consumption. Murrar, Batra, and Rodger (2021) noted that customer satisfaction has two dimensions, which are cumulative satisfaction and transaction-specific satisfaction. Cumulative transaction refers to the overall satisfaction and experience gained repeatedly from the service consumption, while transaction-specific satisfaction originates from customers' usage and experience after services have been availed to them.

Gachau (2016) suggests that satisfied customers have now become an important ingredient for the competitiveness and survival of a business. Organisations should endeavour to provide quality service to their customers (Okoth, 2019). Customer satisfaction is closely related to future buying behaviour and patronage, making it a predictor of customer loyalty and retention. Therefore, it is very important to organisations. A satisfied customer tells five or six people about

their experiences, but a dissatisfied customer will tell ten people about their bad experiences (Ozuem, Ranfagni, Willis, Salvietti, & Howell, 2024).

Several organisations have resulted in product and service differentiation in the globalised market to remain competitive. Service quality has been used as a differentiating factor that increases customer satisfaction. Quality is a key aspect that leads to a pool of loyal customers. Willott (2020) pointed out that 96% of consumers consider service quality of a brand, which results in customer loyalty. Hence, customer retention is developed through an increased level of service quality and customer follow-ups (Yeo, Thai, & Roh, 2015).

Paposa (2019) argues that for the service industry to gain a competitive edge in the market and satisfy customers, they need to deliver superior quality service. They further noted that the ability of the antecedents of the SERVQUAL model, such as responsiveness, tangibility, reliability, empathy and assurance, directly influence customer satisfaction. Customer satisfaction has brought closer the use of the SERVQUAL model in many developing countries today (Sousa & Voss, 2019). Service quality enables service providers with similar services to offer competitive, valuable and unique services, which eventually leads to growth and increased customer satisfaction.

Service quality has played a role in customer satisfaction and organisational performance in the recent past (Paposa, 2019). The service quality aspect has evolved within businesses, consumers' expectations, purchasing experiences, tastes, and preferences have also changed, which has raised concerns about the organization's approach towards the customers. In the competitive era, the service industry should devise strategies that can

differentiate itself from competitors. This is achieved through the provision of superior services to the customers. Service quality is a tool that can be used to gain new clients and gain a competitive advantage ahead of competitors. Previous studies conducted in various service sectors such as banks, tourism, travel, mobile dealers, hotels and airlines indicate customer satisfaction leads to loyalty and retention (Mohammed, Ibrahim, & Ali, 2017). Bengtsson, Herzberg and Rask (2020) established that there is a relationship between service quality and customer satisfaction. Wahid, Dangi, Jabar, Muhamed and Paino (2017) agree that reliability and tangibility influence customer satisfaction.

According to customer service statistics by Willott (2020), 96% of consumers globally consider service quality as important when choosing a brand. Further, 70% of customers portray brand loyalty because of the experience they have had with the service provider. 52% of consumers agreed that they buy additional products of the company based on the previous experience they have had with the company's products or services. Therefore, customer satisfaction and brand loyalty enhance organisational profitability. Though service-offering organisations have tried to differentiate their products and services yet there are complaints from customers who have had unsatisfying encounters with various service providers. There is a need to examine whether service providers are keen on looking at the five dimensions, such as empathy, reliability, responsiveness, assurance and tangibility, which contribute to customer satisfaction if addressed well.

Statement of the Problem

There has been an increase in business dynamics recently as a result of the rapid development of technology and the adoption of social platforms, which has increased customer demand, calling for closer attention. Organisations ought to be on the lookout to be able to offer satisfaction to customers. Satisfied customers are loyal to the organisation's products or services, fostering

growth and profitability. Companies that offer quality services to their customers stand a better chance of gaining a competitive edge in the market environment. Services being heterogeneous in nature and intangible are hard to deal with. Therefore, every encounter a customer has with a service matters and can translate to satisfaction or dissatisfaction. Service sector companies are under great pressure to provide quality service to the customers owing to increased competition in the industry. The customer perception of service may differ from one service provider to another. Service-offering companies should identify service quality dimensions that drive customer perception of quality, which leads to satisfaction. However, this has not been achieved yet because customers continue to complain about various services they receive from the providers. This study will therefore seek to examine existing literature on service quality dimensions that are considered important in the service industry.

Objective of the Study

The objective of the study is to examine the relationship between service quality and customer satisfaction in the service industry. This study specifically examines empathy, assurance, tangibility, reliability and responsiveness quality on customer satisfaction in the service industry.

- To examine the effect of reliability quality on customer satisfaction in the service industry.
- To investigate the influence of responsiveness quality on customer satisfaction in the service industry.
- To establish the influence of assurance quality on customer satisfaction in the service industry.
- To assess the effect of empathy quality on customer satisfaction in the service industry.
- To establish the effect of tangibility quality on customer satisfaction in the service industry.

THEORETICAL REVIEW

SERVQUAL Model (Theory)

The model was developed by American marketers Parasuraman, Valarie Zeithaml and Leonard Berry in (1985). The model is used as a method of capturing and measuring the service quality experience by the customers. The model compares the expected service quality with actual experience, and it is based on five dimensions such as assurance, empathy, tangibles, reliability and responsiveness. According to Parasuraman, Zeithaml and Berry (1988), the model is a multi-dimensional research instrument utilised in measuring expectations of the respondents using the five dimensions of service quality. The model was developed over a five-year period, taking place from 1983 to 1988. Research findings were based on the five dimensions, which are seen as the main components of service quality (Parasuraman, Zeithaml, and Berry, 1985; 1988).

Critics of SERVQUAL have pointed out that the issue of face validity and construct validity in the development of the model, since the model used a five-year questionnaire experiment design. The model is based on matching individual perspectives with individual expectations, which may not always be possible. According to Souca (2011), in conference proceedings, the model based on the issue of face validity was preferably a customer satisfaction model rather than service quality. Since a validity issue arose in the conceptualisation of the service quality RATER dimension. On the other hand, Smith (1995) also pointed out the adoption of a modified scale, which also raised issues of validity of the dimension. Hence proposed that the specific contexts of the service industry might affect the dimensions. Other concerns are the ambiguity of expectations, a construct based on the model structure. However, over the years, the model has survived criticism but leaves room for improvement.

The SERVQUAL model indicates the need for service quality based on bridging the gap of customers' expectations with their perception of

service delivery (Ghotbabadi, Feiz, & Baharun, 2015). This is achieved using five dimensions, which are responsiveness, assurance, tangibles, and empathy in line with customers' needs. The original model contained ten dimensions, which are tangibles, security, credibility, communication, courtesy, access, competence, assurance, responsiveness and reliability (Gi-DU & Jeffrey, 2004).

The model has been simplified to five dimensions to reduce the bulkiness of the indicators of SERVQUAL oriented in service expectation and service performance. This yields customer satisfaction when the customer receives service quality dimensions. Khurana (2019) posits that competency, assurance, tangibility and credibility dimensions were found to have a higher impact on customer satisfaction. Other than customer satisfaction, Qasem and Alhakimi (2019) link service quality with customer loyalty.

The model enables organisations to be acquainted with factors that influence customer expectancy patterns, also it helps organization to improve customer satisfaction by taking the pattern in advance. Satisfied customers whose expectations have been met are important for business survival (Gachau, 2016). Ozuem et al. (2024) also argue that satisfied customers will make recommendations via word of mouth about the experience they have had with the service. The model's relevance to the service industry is the essence of acting as the gap bridger that occurs in the service sector. These gaps are the knowledge gap, standard gap, delivery gap, communication gap and satisfaction gap.

Expectancy Disconfirmation Theory of Customer Satisfaction

The expectancy-value concept and disconfirmation theory were developed by Oliver in 1977. The theory postulated that positive disconfirmation, which refers to better performance than expected, results in satisfaction, while negative disconfirmation, which is worse performance than expected, leads to dissatisfaction (Oliver, 1977). According to

Oliver, the greater the difference between the performance and expectation, the greater the disconfirmation (Spreng, Scott, & Richard, 1996).

Critics of this theory point out that there is a weak measure that can be adopted to measure expectation or perceived performance of the product (Van-Ryzin & Etienne, 2010). According to Grimmlikhuijsen and Porumbescu (2017), the expectation disconfirmation model makes the assumption that there is no cognitive bias which may lead to dissatisfaction or satisfaction. This implies that there are factors like cognitive bias that can affect dissatisfaction or satisfaction, other than disconfirmation based on performance and expectation.

Zhang, Chen, Petrovsky and Walker (2021) suggest that the predominant approach of the expectancy-disconfirmation model is appropriate in explaining customer satisfaction in the product or service industry. Hence, there is a need for the organisation to improve service quality in order to create positive disconfirmation, which leads to satisfaction. In the current research, customer satisfaction can be determined by service quality, which provides positive disconfirmation. The service provider can achieve this by creating a better impression of the service by ensuring better service quality to overcome the expectation of customer.

Empirical Review

The section provides empirical literature based on service quality and customer satisfaction. This gives direction on the discussion leading to the conclusion and recommendations. Customer satisfaction has drawn closer the usage of the SERVQUAL model in both developed and developing countries in the recent past (Sousa & Voss, 2019). Providing quality service to customers enhances health competition among the industry and allows growth and eventually customer satisfaction among organisations (Mohammed, Ibrahim, & Ali, 2017). It is therefore very important for organisations to endeavour to offer quality service to the

customers to retain them and compete well in the current environment (Mohammed, Ibrahim, & Ali, 2017). Willott (2020) reports that customer satisfaction and brand loyalty improve organisational profitability

Bengtsson, Herzberg and Rask (2020) conducted a study on service quality, customer satisfaction and brand loyalty among Generation Y and Generation X in Sweden. The study focused on establishing how different generations view service quality, satisfaction and brand loyalty. The study adopted cross section survey design. The results show that service quality had a positive relationship with customer age, and customer occupation was seen as the most important demographic variable, which significantly influenced the overall service quality perception. Further, management gains better knowledge of how customers gauge service quality and key areas that need to be addressed carefully by the service providers. The author focused on the age of the customer and occupation, while service quality and customer satisfaction are triggered by other factors rather than age only.

Qasem and Alhakimi (2019) examined the effect of quality communication in developing customer loyalty mediated by customer satisfaction. The study targeted Yemen's banking industry. A sample of 233 customers was utilised in non-probability sampling to determine the research respondents. Data was collected using questionnaires. The findings indicate that customers' higher level of perception of service quality and communication results in greater perceptions of loyalty. Further, satisfaction mediates the promotion of customer loyalty in the banking sector by ensuring effective communication and excellent service quality. Since the promotion of customer loyalty is key in the service industry, the study would contribute some knowledge on the strategies to be adopted. The study, however, focused on one sampling technique to pick respondents, and only one instrument of data collection. Further, the study could have been carried out in a product context.

Khan and Fasih (2014) examined the impact of service quality on customer satisfaction and customer loyalty. The study aimed at the satisfaction level of banking customers, the quality of different services provided by the banks and loyalty to the bank. A survey questionnaire was given public and private sectors using stratified random sampling to 270 banks' customers. One-sample t-test, regression and correlation analysis were used. The results indicated service quality dimension had a positive and significant relationship with customer satisfaction and loyalty. The study focused on customer loyalty; therefore, there is a need to examine dimensions and customer satisfaction in the service industry.

Yao, Darun and Ismail (2014) investigated service quality and customer satisfaction in Malaysia. A survey questionnaire entails 150 passengers who took rapid Kuantan in Kuantan on routes 100, 200 and 300. The study used the five dimensions of service quality, that is, reliability, tangibility, responsiveness, assurance and empathy. According to the results, the five dimensions of service quality had a significant effect on customer satisfaction.

Okoth (2019) conducted a study on the relationship between service quality dimensions and customer satisfaction in Nairobi bakeries. The research employed a cross-sectional design, and a convenient sampling technique was utilised to pick 92 respondents. The study deduced that all service quality dimensions had a significant relationship with customer satisfaction. The study findings concur with several other scholars who found that all dimensions of service quality significantly influence customer satisfaction.

Reliability, Quality, and Customer Satisfaction

Ibrahim, Mohd, Mohd and Saharuddin (2015) examined the effect of customer satisfaction on reliability and responsiveness. The results were based on self-service provided by a Malaysian bank, where customers were examined on reliability and responsiveness in relation to customer satisfaction. An observation list was

used, and questionnaires were given to 271 customers at the self-service point. Their results indicated that timeliness, dependability and consistency optimised customer satisfaction. Hence, reliability and timely responsiveness were significant for customer satisfaction. They focused on two dimensions of service quality, triggering the need for further investigation on the five dimensions of service quality.

Reliability and tangibility service quality were assessed by Wahid, Dangi, Jabar, Muhamed and Paino (2017) on customer satisfaction. Based on 102 customers, tangibility quality was below reliability quality. The regression analysis results indicate that there was a significant positive relationship between tangibility and reliability quality and customer satisfaction ($\beta_1 = .676$, $p = .000$; $\beta_2 = .466$, $p = .000$). Hence, they concluded that tangibility and reliability quality significantly affect customer satisfaction.

Responsiveness, Quality, and Customer Satisfaction

Uyoga and Lagat (2019) researched the relationship between customer responsiveness, service performance and satisfaction. A sample of 426 customers of Kenya's airline was utilised. The findings indicated that customers perceived higher satisfaction based on the responsiveness of the airline, leading to high service performance. Service performance mediated the relationship between customer responsiveness and customer satisfaction.

In the study conducted by Wambugu (2018) on the effect of service quality dimensions on customer satisfaction in Kenya. Service accessibility, efficiency, responsiveness and service reliability on customer satisfaction were investigated. Results reveal that customer responsiveness, service accessibility, service efficiency and service reliability significantly affect customer satisfaction of Huduma centres. The study recommended that the government put in place policies to enhance the quality of services offered. Also, the study suggests training

employees on customer relationships to improve satisfaction.

Assurance, Quality, and Customer Satisfaction

Service, assurance and efficiency were investigated on customer satisfaction by Salihu and Metin (2017). Product improvements, efficiency and reliability of electronic banking, especially e-banking and ATM Cards, were assessed on customer satisfaction. Using questionnaires, the study found that there existed a strong correlation between reliability and service. However, efficiency had a weak correlation with customer satisfaction. Service assurance and reliability had positive significantly on customer satisfaction.

Chege (2020) investigated the relationship between service quality dimensions and customer satisfaction in the insurance industry in Kenya. The study serves as a model for expectancy disconfirmation theory, assimilation-contrast theory, equity theory, script theory and the negativity theory. A descriptive research design was employed with a target population of 17 licensed composite companies. A sample size of 400 respondents was drawn using a simple random sampling technique. The study used primary data, which was collected through questionnaires. Results indicate that there was a positive significant relationship between customer satisfaction and service reliability, and proposed the “RESA” model for the insurance industry in Kenya. The study concluded that service empathy, service reliability, service blueprint and service assurance dimensions significantly relate to customer satisfaction. The study suggested that insurance companies should improve the four service quality dimensions to achieve full customer satisfaction. On the other hand, the study focused on one specific industry as opposed to the current study.

Empathy Quality and Customer Satisfaction

A study by Bahadur, Aziz and Zulfiqar (2018) analysed employee empathy on customer satisfaction and loyalty. A survey of 360

responses in the telecommunication service in China was used. Structural equation modelling was used in the analysis. The findings revealed that there was a significant positive effect of employee empathy on customer satisfaction and loyalty, which was based on word-of-mouth and repurchase intentions. However, the focus was on the telecommunication industry, whereas this study will focus on the service industry by reviewing empirical literature.

Mutinda (2020) examined the effect of service quality and customer satisfaction in the hotel industry in Nairobi County. The study used 385 customers as respondents and a convenience sampling technique. The study findings pointed out that tangibility and empathy had a significant positive influence on customer satisfaction, while other service quality dimensions were insignificant. The study suggests that hotel set-up should be appealing to customers, employees' neatness should be observed to enhance customer satisfaction and improve firm productivity.

Tangibility, Quality and Customer Satisfaction

Shukri, Yajid and Tham (2020) investigated the role of responsiveness, reliability and tangibility on customer satisfaction in Malaysia. Data was collected from managers and customers. Tangibility, reliability and responsiveness were found to have positive associations with customer satisfaction. The current study used a meta-analysis of empirical data.

Khurana (2019) examined the relationship between service quality and customer choice in the Indian life insurance industry. The sample size of 200 customers was selected randomly from ten life insurance companies. The results reveal that customer expectations and perceptions towards the competency, tangibility, assurance and credibility dimensions of service quality have a great influence on customer satisfaction. This may imply that customers are keen on these dimensions. This is supported by the findings of Mutinda (2020).

An analysis of port service quality was done by Yeo, Thai and Roh (2015) on customer satisfaction in Korean Container ports. The study used 314 members of Korean Port Logistics containers. Partial Least Squares Structural Equation Modelling was used on service quality dimensions. These came from five constructs of service quality and its management, company image and social responsibility factor, which had a positive significant effect on customer satisfaction. Hence, the study has more factors than the five-dimensional SERVQUAL model dimension.

Knowledge Gap

There are both contextual, conceptual and methodological gaps that are identified.

Ibrahim, Mohd, Mohd and Saharuddin (2015) focused on reliability and responsiveness and customer satisfaction with a sample of 271 and used an observation list, while Wa-hid, Dangi, Jabar, Muhamed and Paino (2017) assessed reliability and tangibility service quality with a sample of 102 respondents. They both reveal conceptual gaps and methodological gaps. Uyoga and Lagat (2019) assessed responsiveness in Kenyan airlines, and Wambugu (2018) examined service accessibility, efficiency, responsiveness and reliability on customer satisfaction in the Huduma Centre. Service assurance, efficiency and customer satisfaction were investigated by Salihu and Metin (2017). Chege (2020) investigated the relationship between service quality dimensions and customer satisfaction in the insurance industry. The study has conceptual, contextual, and methodological gaps that this review seeks to address.

Bahadur, Aziz and Zulfiqar (2018) analysed employee empathy on customer satisfaction and

loyalty. Using a survey of 360 respondents of telecommunication service in China, Mutinda (2020) examined the effect of service quality and customer satisfaction in the hotel industry in Nairobi County with 385 customers as the respondents. Their findings vary, and there is context, constructs, and methodology as well. This empirical review seeks to address the gap by examining the five service quality dimensions on customer satisfaction.

Shukri, Yajid and Tham (2020) investigated the role of responsiveness, reliability and tangibility on customer satisfaction in Malaysia. An analysis of port service quality was done by Yeo, Thai and Roh (2015) on customer satisfaction in Korean Container ports. The study used 314 members of the Korean Port Logistics containers. Partial Least Square Structural Equation Modelling was used on service quality dimensions. Khurana (2019) examined the relationship between service quality and customer choice in the Indian life insurance industry. The sample size of 200 customers was selected randomly from ten life insurance companies; this presents a contextual, conceptual and methodological gap.

Qasem and Alhakimi (2019) found a conceptual gap developed by the mediating role of customer satisfaction on service quality and customer loyalty. Yeo, Thai and Roh (2015) used Partial Least Square Structural Equation Modelling. Khan and Fasih (2014) used the T-test, regression and correlation, creating a methodological gap. While Yao, Darun and Ismail (2014) used a survey questionnaire of 150 passengers on routes 100, 200 and 300 of the Rapid Kuantan. This necessitates further investigation into service quality dimensions and customer satisfaction.

Table 1: Summary of Key Gaps from Empirical Literature on Service Quality and Customer Satisfaction

Author(s) & Year	Focus of the Study	Context / Country	Methodology Used	Key Findings	Identified Gaps
Bengtsson, Herzberg & Rask (2020)	Service quality, customer satisfaction, and brand loyalty among Gen Y and Gen X	Sweden	Cross-sectional survey	Service quality positively related to age; occupation influenced service perception.	Focused only on demographics (age & occupation); ignored other service quality dimensions – conceptual gap.
Qasem & Alhakimi (2019)	Effect of service quality and communication on loyalty mediated by satisfaction	Yemen banking industry	Questionnaires, non-probability sampling (n=233)	Communication and service quality enhance loyalty via satisfaction	Single data collection method and context-specific; limited generalizability – methodological and contextual gap
Khan & Fasih (2014)	Service quality, satisfaction, and loyalty	Pakistan (banking sector)	T-test, regression, correlation (n=270)	Positive relationship among service quality, satisfaction, and loyalty	Focused on loyalty rather than all SERVQUAL dimensions – conceptual gap
Yao, Darun & Ismail (2014)	Service quality and satisfaction among bus passengers	Malaysia	Survey (n=150)	Five SERVQUAL dimensions had a significant impact on satisfaction	Limited to the transport sector; small sample size – contextual and methodological gap
Okoth (2019)	Service quality and customer satisfaction	Nairobi, Kenya (bakeries)	Cross-sectional, convenience sampling (n=92)	All SERVQUAL dimensions significantly related to satisfaction	Limited to one sector; small sample – contextual gap
Ibrahim et al. (2015)	Reliability and responsiveness on customer satisfaction	Malaysia (banking)	Observation & questionnaires (n=271)	Timeliness and dependability improved satisfaction	Only two dimensions studied – conceptual gap
Wahid et al. (2017)	Tangibility & reliability and customer satisfaction	Malaysia	Regression (n=102)	Both dimensions had a positive significant impact	Focused on limited dimensions; small sample – conceptual and methodological gap

Author(s) & Year	Focus of the Study	Context / Country	Methodology Used	Key Findings	Identified Gaps
Uyoga & Lagat (2019)	Responsiveness, service performance, and satisfaction	Kenya (airlines)	Survey (n=426)	Responsiveness improved satisfaction via performance	Focused only on one dimension; context-specific – conceptual and contextual gap
Wambugu (2018)	Service accessibility, efficiency, responsiveness, reliability, and satisfaction	Kenya (Huduma Centres)	Descriptive survey	All dimensions significant	Focused on public service; needs validation in private sector – contextual gap
Salihu & Metin (2017)	Service assurance, efficiency, reliability and satisfaction	Turkey (e-banking)	Questionnaires	Reliability & assurance strongly correlated with satisfaction	Limited scope of dimensions; focused on e-banking only – conceptual and contextual gap
Chege (2020)	Service quality and satisfaction in insurance industry	Kenya	Descriptive design (n=400)	Reliability, empathy, assurance, blueprint significant	Focused on one industry; need for multi-sector validation – contextual and methodological gap
Bahadur, Aziz & Zulfiqar (2018)	Employee empathy, satisfaction and loyalty	China (telecom sector)	SEM (n=360)	Empathy positively influenced satisfaction and loyalty	Focused on one dimension and sector; lacks cross-sector comparison – conceptual and contextual gap
Mutinda (2020)	Service quality and satisfaction	Kenya (hotel industry)	Convenience sampling (n=385)	Tangibility and empathy significant; others insignificant	Variation in dimensional significance; needs sectoral validation – conceptual gap
Shukri, Yajid & Tham (2020)	Responsiveness, reliability, tangibility, and satisfaction	Malaysia	Meta-analysis	All three had positive relationships with satisfaction	Limited to selected dimensions; secondary data – conceptual gap
Khurana (2019)	Service quality and customer choice	India (insurance)	Random sampling (n=200)	Tangibility, assurance, and credibility influenced satisfaction	Sector-specific focus; narrow construct scope – contextual gap

Author(s) & Year	Focus of the Study	Context / Country	Methodology Used	Key Findings	Identified Gaps
Yeo, Thai & Roh (2015)	Port service quality and satisfaction	South Korea (container ports)	PLS-SEM (n=314)	Service quality, image, and CSR affected satisfaction	Used extended SERVQUAL; different constructs – conceptual gap

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

The study adopted a meta-analysis design that utilises an analysis of existing literature. The meta-analysis design allows the researcher to collect necessary evidence from journals, reports and books. This included all research journals, reports and books that are peer-reviewed between the period of 2014 to 2025 on service quality and customer satisfaction. This combines numerous research studies, as indicated by Saunders, Lewis, & Thornhill (2011), to form conclusive, valid evidence of the objective. Therefore, the results are given as an aggregate opinion collected from different authors' results. This finding was therefore sufficient for making appropriate decision criteria in the study.

The study synthesised literature findings that focused on service quality in relation to customer satisfaction. This was done through screening results based on the theme of reliability, tangibility, responsiveness, assurance and empathy. The synthesis of the literature per theme provided general information on the objective. The information was used to conclude the study.

DISCUSSION OF FINDINGS

The SERVQUAL model provides conceptual indicators that are appropriate for measuring service quality based on 5 years analysis of five dimensions. These dimensions are reliability, assurance, tangibles, empathy and responsiveness (RATER). Despite some critics indicating that RATER is a biased measure of customer satisfaction, most of the empirical studies have adopted the model. This view was also held by assimilation theory, which tries to bridge the gap between customer expectations and perceived product performance. Dissonance in their

relationship would lead to satisfaction or dissatisfaction.

Paposa (2019) revealed that there is a relationship between service quality and customer satisfaction. However, service quality was examined from the customer's point of view. Khura-na (2019) found that customer expectations and perceptions using the credibility, competency, assurance, and tangibility service quality dimensions had more impact on customer satisfaction, where customer choice was examined. The results from Bengtsson, Hertzberg and Rask (2020) revealed that there was no significant difference between Generation Y and X in customer loyalty. Service quality had a high influence on participants' satisfaction and loyalty. According to Qasem and Alhakimi (2019), service quality and communication have a higher impact on customer satisfaction and loyalty. However, there is a mediating effect of customer satisfaction on the relationship between service quality and customer loyalty.

Reliability, Quality, and Customer Satisfaction

The results from Iberahim, Mohd, Mohd and Saharuddin (2015) indicated that timeliness, dependability and consistency affected customer satisfaction. Therefore, related that reliability and timely responsiveness were significant to customer satisfaction. In a related study, Wahid, Dangi, Jabar, Muhamed, and Paino (2017) found that tangibility and reliability quality had a significant relationship with customer satisfaction. Therefore, there existed a significant relationship between reliability quality and customer satisfaction (Yao, Darun & Ismail, 2014).

Responsiveness, Quality and Customer Satisfaction

Responsiveness of employees in Kenya Airways was found to have higher customer satisfaction according to Uyoga and Lagat (2019). The study also revealed that service performance mediated the relationship between responsiveness quality and customer satisfaction. In a related study, Wambugu (2018) found that customer responsiveness, service accessibility, service efficiency and service reliability had a significant effect on customer satisfaction in Huduma centres. There exists a trend that reveals that the responsiveness quality in service has a significant effect on customer satisfaction. Hence, they should be treated as key by the service providers who are trying to differentiate their package for customers.

Assurance, Quality, and Customer Satisfaction

According to Salihu and Metin (2017), there is a positive effect of assurance and reliability quality on customer satisfaction in electronic banking. Chege (2020) also found that assurance had a significant relationship with customer satisfaction. Besides service assurance, the study also found that service blueprint, service empathy and service reliability had a significant relationship with customer satisfaction. Therefore, the study indicates that the empathy quality of service has a significant effect on customer satisfaction.

Empathy Quality and Customer Satisfaction

Word-of-mouth and repurchase intentions were some of the customer satisfaction and loyalty that were found to be affected by employee empathy, according to Bahadur, Aziz and Zulfiqar (2018). Similarly, Mutinda (2020) found that empathy and tangibility had a significant positive influence on customer satisfaction. These reveal that empathy has a significant influence on customer satisfaction.

Tangibility Quality and Customer Satisfaction

According to the results from Shukri, Yajid and Tham (2020), there existed positive nexuses

between tangibility, reliability and responsiveness on customer satisfaction. Similarly, Khurana (2019) found that competency, tangibility, assurance and credibility dimensions had greater influence on customer satisfaction. Yeo, Thai and Roh (2015) pointed out that tangibility has a positive and significant relationship with customer satisfaction.

CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

Conclusion

The study revealed that the SERVQUAL model is still appropriate in explaining the indicators of service quality, which include: reliability, assurance, tangibles, empathy and responsiveness. On the other hand, the theory of assimilation explains the customer satisfaction created by the customer adjusting the dissonance between the customer's expectations and the perceived product performance.

The study also concluded that different SERVQUAL model dimensions have different impacts on customer satisfaction. However, customer satisfaction has been found to have a mediating effect between service quality and customer loyalty. The SERVQUAL model indicators have been examined on customer loyalty and customer satisfaction by many scholars. However, customer expectations and perceptions toward tangibility, assurance, competency and credibility dimensions of service quality were found to have more impact on customer satisfaction. There is a need to examine the relationship between service quality and customer satisfaction using primary data.

The study concluded that reliability quality, responsiveness quality, assurance quality, empathy quality and tangibility quality have a significant relationship on customer satisfaction. Therefore, organisations that are charged with service provision, such as banks, communication companies, hotels, travel companies, among others, should endeavour to employ strategies that will enhance service quality. Quality is the key

factor that gives customers reason to purchase and repurchase a company's products or services.

Recommendations

The study recommends the improvement of the reliability of the services through creating consistent quality in technique, quality and timeliness. This will ensure dependable service. The study recommends that organisations should adopt the use of customer care services to increase the responsiveness of customers. Those who have customer service can be improved through the adoption of ICT to track complaints.

The study suggests that organisations should assure customers through rigorous promotions, customer relationships and reviews for tech companies. This would eventually give customers an understanding of the quality of services provided.

Empathy can be achieved through training the customer care and customer relationship departments. For those with complaints, empathy would assist in reducing the negative impact of the complaints and enable the organisation to provide assurance.

Finally, the study recommends that organisations should ensure a high-quality experience during service provision. This will ensure that the organisation gains a competitive advantage. Future research should be done in longitudinal rather than meta-analysis.

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